

From: Bishoy Zaki Bishoy.Zaki@UGent.be
Subject: Fw: Cambridge Elements - Decision on Elements-HSS3-2024-0018.R1
Date: April 28, 2026 at 6:15 AM
To: Nowlin, Matthew Christopher matthew.nowlin@uta.edu, Nowlin, Matt nowlinmc@cofc.edu

BZ

Dear Matt,

Hope all is good on your side. Kindly find below the elements decision, seems we are in for another round. What are your thoughts?

Bishoy

From: Cambridge Elements HSS3 <onbehalf@manuscriptcentral.com>
Sent: Tuesday, April 28, 2026 1:50 PM
To: Bishoy Zaki <Bishoy.Zaki@UGent.be>
Subject: Cambridge Elements - Decision on Elements-HSS3-2024-0018.R1

28-Apr-2026

Dear Prof. Louis Zaki,

Elements-HSS3-2024-0018.R1 entitled "POLICY LEARNING AND INFORMATION PROCESSING DYNAMICS" which you submitted to Cambridge Elements, has been reviewed. The comments of the reviewer(s) and editor are included at the bottom of this letter.

While the reviewer(s) and editor recognise the potential of your manuscript as a valuable contribution to the journal, they also suggest some major revisions to your manuscript. Therefore, I invite you to respond to their comments and revise your manuscript.

To start your revision now, click the link below:

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When submitting your revised manuscript, you will be able to respond to the comments made by the reviewer(s) in the space provided. Please use this space to document any changes you make to the original manuscript. In order to expedite the processing of the revised manuscript, please be as specific as possible in your response to the reviewer(s).

Because we are trying to facilitate timely publication of manuscripts submitted to Cambridge Elements, your revised manuscript should be uploaded as soon as possible. We expect to receive your revision by 09-Jun-2026. If it is not possible for you to submit your revision by this date, please contact the Editorial Office to rearrange the due date. Otherwise we may have to consider your paper as a new submission.

Once again, thank you for submitting your manuscript to Cambridge Elements and I look forward to receiving your revision.

Sincerely,
Dr. M. Ramesh
Series Editor, Cambridge Elements

Associate Editor: Araral, Eduardo
Comments to the Author:

Here is a more concise, integrated version of your comment that preserves your key points while improving flow and clarity:

I appreciate the authors' efforts in revising the manuscript. However, several core issues remain.

First, the writing would benefit from being clearer, simpler, and more engaging, especially for readers outside public policy (e.g., public management or sociology). At present, the manuscript relies heavily on dense and technical language that can be difficult to follow. For example, phrases in the abstract such as "heralded as a versatile... often treated as an ontology of the policy process" and "theoretical and analytical fineness... micro-foundations remains embryonic" are not easily interpretable. Simplifying language and briefly explaining key concepts would significantly improve accessibility. It may be useful to have a non-expert reader review the manuscript to identify unclear wording.

Second, the manuscript's overall purpose and main contributions are still not sufficiently स्पष्ट. The authors should more clearly articulate what the manuscript aims to achieve and what it adds to the literature. A figure showing how the manuscript is organized—how chapters connect and how the theoretical arguments develop—would help guide readers.

Third, the presentation of tables needs improvement. Table 4.1 includes starred values without explanation; notes clarifying significance levels should be added, along with standard errors and/or t-values. Descriptive statistics and correlation matrices are also missing and should be

reported. Table 5.1 is similarly unclear, and the meaning of “X” should be explicitly defined.

Fourth, the authors’ claim that response rates are “not a useful metric” when using platforms such as Qualtrics or Survey Sampling International is problematic. In Econometrics and related fields, response rates are important for assessing potential bias (e.g., nonresponse bias). If response rate information is unavailable, this should be acknowledged as a limitation rather than dismissed.

Finally, the discussion of policy innovation remains underdeveloped despite its close relationship with policy learning. The manuscript would benefit from a more substantive engagement with relevant literature, including Goyal et al. (2025), Kemmerling (2023), Huang & Wiebrecht (2021), and Xun Wu and M. Ramesh (2014). Strengthening this connection would enhance the manuscript’s theoretical contribution.

Overall, the topic is important, but further revisions are needed to improve clarity, transparency, and theoretical development.

Reviewer: 1

Comments to the Author

I appreciate the authors’ effort in revising the manuscript. However, several of the same issues remain. The writing could be simpler and more easily understood by students and readers who are not public policy scholars (e.g., those in public management or sociology). The text could also be more engaging. Using simpler language or briefly explaining key concepts would help achieve this goal. For example, even in the abstract, if I were not a reviewer, I would not continue reading the book after reading the abstract. For instance, the abstract includes phrases such as “heralded as a versatile... often treated as an ontology of the policy process.” What does this mean? Similarly, the second sentence includes “theoretical and analytical fineness... micro-foundations remains embryonic.” What does this mean?

Perhaps the authors could ask a student who is not an expert in the field to read the manuscript. Such a reader could go through the manuscript line by line and identify which word choices and sentences are unclear.

After reading the manuscript again, it is still not clear to me what the manuscript ultimately aims to achieve and what its main contributions are. Perhaps the authors could include a figure illustrating how the book is organized, how each chapter connects to the others, and how the theories are explained in the future.

The tables could also be more user-friendly and provide the necessary information. For example, in Table 4.1, some numbers are marked with stars. A note should explain what these stars refer to. It would also be helpful to provide standard errors and/or t-values.

As I mentioned early, I did not see tables reporting descriptive statistics and correlation coefficients used in the study.

Table 5.1 is also not user-friendly. What does the “X” mean in this table?

Previously, I recommended providing the response rate, and here is the authors’ response: “Additionally, with firms like Survey Sampling International and Qualtrics, researchers pay for a specific number of respondents (e.g., 1000), and data collection continues until that specific number is reached, while also accounting for the quotas. Therefore, response rate is not a useful metric.” I think this statement (“response rate is not a useful metric”) is problematic. The discipline of econometrics is largely concerned with bias (including sample bias and nonresponse bias). If this information is not available, it should be acknowledged as a limitation of the study rather than described as “not useful information.” If an organizational psychologist were to review the manuscript, the paper might be rejected automatically because of this statement. See: Wooldridge, J. M. (2010). *Econometric analysis of cross section and panel data*. Boston: MIT Press. In other words, simply acknowledging this as a limitation would be wiser than not accepting it as a limitation.

Previously, I also recommended adding more discussion of policy innovation, as it is closely connected to policy learning (for example, innovation can lead to learning, and learning can also lead to innovation). This connection is still not sufficiently developed, so I recommend expanding the discussion of these links. In the previous round, I suggested the following readings, but they do not appear to be integrated into the manuscript:

Goyal, N., et al. (2025). From Niches to the Mainstream: A Computational Review and Research Agenda for Policy Innovation. *Journal of Comparative Policy Analysis: Research and Practice*, 1–20.

Kemmerling, A. (2023). Policy Innovation in the Global South and South–North Policy Learning. *Journal of Comparative Policy Analysis: Research and Practice*, 25(5), 475–486.

There is also other relevant work on policy innovation, such as:

Huang, B., & Wiebrecht, F. (2021). The dynamic role of governments in adopting policy innovations in China. *Policy & Politics*, 49(4), 633–651.

Wu, X., & Ramesh, M. (2014). Market imperfections, government imperfections, and policy mixes: policy innovations in Singapore. *Policy Sciences*, 47(3), 305–320. doi:10.1007/s11077-013-9186-x.

Reviewer: 2

Comments to the Author

I would like to thank the authors for the revisions to the paper. Nevertheless, after going through the manuscript a second time, my impression is that the changes made are largely minor and did not address the major comments indicated in the first round of revisions. I will therefore try to make my criticism somewhat more explicit.

In its current shape, the book reads to me like a conflation of two different research agendas. On the one hand, there is an attempt to summarize the entire breadth of literature that can be related to policy learning — whether implicitly or explicitly. However, this enterprise does not do justice to such a broad literature and, in doing so, remains quite superficial. For example, the distinction between micro, meso, and macro elements of learning is not particularly helpful, because it is underdeveloped. Learning is always related to the individual level and needs to be translated to the meso and macro-level. This aspect is not discussed sufficiently in the book and not illustrated with examples.

Then, there is a rapid overview of different types and modes of learning that is, as the authors themselves acknowledge, incomplete — but the concepts are not explained at all and not used in the rest of the book. I am therefore left wondering what the purpose of this broad introduction is. It is not deep enough to be a presentation of the learning literature, but it is also not specific enough to be an introduction to what follows.

This concern is all the more pressing when we turn to the second part of the book, which attempts to develop a framework around information processing and the micro level of policy learning. Here again, the analysis begins with the advocacy coalition framework, which is concerned with something quite different from public opinion that becomes part of empirical research that follows. If the authors were doing what they claim to be doing, they would need to engage seriously with the research on information processing in politics and extend it to voters. There are a number of publications related to the punctuated equilibrium framework that deal with information processing that can be found easily. It would make much more sense to use this approach when developing an empirical analysis of policy learning based on the examination of one event and public opinion data. I can see a contribution in this manuscript, but the current version is still very far away from it.

In summary, while the manuscript addresses an important topic, it does not engage sufficiently with the relevant literature, the arguments are not developed with enough depth, and the different parts do not fit together well. Furthermore, an Elements piece — which should be dedicated to developing new ideas or presenting a coherent research agenda — is not well served by what is done here. Eventually, it is up to the editors to decide this question, however, in this case I feel that this manuscript needs to strengthen its coherence and fit with the series.

The result feels like two insufficiently developed research projects that have been awkwardly combined. I apologize for the somewhat undiplomatic way I have put this, but I am left with the impression that the authors have not taken the review process seriously, nor fully appreciated the extent of the revisions that would be required to make this a coherent contribution to the literature.